IN HIGH-STAKES corporate leadership meetings, silence is often misconstrued as lack of ideas or confidence. Executive presence coach Vikram recalls working with a senior business leader who remained quiet during crucial strategy discussions—not for lack of commercial insight, but because he was mentally translating his thoughts into English and trying to frame grammatically perfect sentences. By the time he was ready to speak, the conversation had moved on.

The coaching focused on shorter sentences, one clear point at a time, and dropping the pursuit of perfect syntax. Once he stopped worrying about linguistic perfection, colleagues recognised the depth of his strategic thinking. As Vikram puts it: "People will forgive imperfect grammar. But they struggle to follow unclear thinking."

Rohan Sethi (name changed on request), a senior HR leader with nearly two decades of corporate experience, describes a similar journey. Although he studied in an English-medium school, he grew up in a Hindi-speaking environment where English was rarely used in everyday conversation. "I found that English was not just a business language but, at times, a source of influence and confidence. I began consciously observing how senior leaders communicated and gradually worked on my own fluency."

One challenge stood out: translating a thought into English in real time during group discussions. "A strong idea was lost simply because I was still framing it in my head while the conversation moved on." His response was to strengthen the content of his communication, build deeper subject knowledge, speak more slowly, and use pauses and body language to reinforce what he was saying.

Real-world evidence of executives succeeding despite unconventional language paths is beginning to surface across corporate India. At Rassense Pvt Ltd, a food services and facility management company, Managing Director & CEO Sanjay Kumar points to real operational examples within his white-collar leadership team. A food and beverage controller in his early 30s routinely begins high-level corporate presentations in English before switching fluidly to

FINDING THE RIGHT FIT

	HIGH ENGLISH DEMAND	FUNCTIONAL OUTPUT FIRST
ROLES	Sales, Marketing, Investor Relations, Board/CXO Interactions	Software Engineering, Operations, Supply Chain, Accounting
FOCUS	Persuasion, global cross-border acquisitions, crisis communications	Subject mastery, technical output, internal problem-solving
STAGE	Entry-level recruitment screening & CXO/Board-level leadership	Mid-level execution & regional management

BEYOND THE ENGLISH FILTER

- **English fluency often serves as an informal screening filter, but it measures linguistic polish rather than strategic capability**
- **While client-facing roles, investor relations, and CXO interactions still require strong English, technical domains like software, operations, and finance prioritise domain mastery over syntax**